



"Highway of Death"

This name was given to the road leading north out of Kuwait City, which is lined with the remains of destroyed cars and trucks. It was heavily bombed by the coalition while blocked with retreating Iraqi forces.

Iraq. The progress of the Second Gulf War, or Iraq War, was rapid and by April 9 the coalition forces took the Iraqi capital, Baghdad. Fully expecting that the war would soon be over, the US appointed a governing council to supervise the creation of a new Iraqi government. However, in many ways, the Iraq War was only just beginning.

Continuing violence

The toppling of Saddam Hussein created national chaos as fighting erupted between different religious and ethnic Iraqi factions. In July 2003 George W. Bush reported that his forces now faced a "low-intensity" war. A brutal and bloody conflict has ensued

involving suicide bombings and guerrilla-style tactics. Although the US handed sovereignty back to Iraq in 2004 and Iraq subsequently elected a government, thousands of Iraqi civilians, police, allied soldiers, and political insurgents (rebels) have died since the fall of Baghdad.

A fight for power

Iraq's new government is Shi'a Muslim dominated, while insurgent groups are mainly Sunni Muslims. Shi'a Muslims are the second-largest denomination of the Islamic faith and adhere only to the teachings of Muhammad and the religious guidance of his family or his descendants. Sunni Muslims are the largest denomination of Islam and represent a branch of Islam that accepted the caliphate (leadership) of Abu Bakr, as Muhammad's friend and successor.

The ongoing violence in Iraq is not simply directed against the foreign troops still attempting to keep the peace on Iraqi soil, but is increasingly a fight for power between rival religious and political factions. The Islamic terrorist group Al-Qaeda,

which carried out the 9/11 attacks (see p.467), is among the many factions operating in Iraq today.

The war with Iraq was controversial, and large demonstrations in Europe and the US protested against it. In Iraq itself, although the insurgency seemed to have subsided by 2010, violence continued in many provinces. The new US president, Barack Obama, withdrew US combat troops from Iraq by August 2010, but 50,000 US service personnel remained in an advisory capacity. Elections in 2010 produced a stalemate between pro-Sunni and pro-Shi'a groups and eight months after the vote a new government had still not been sworn in.



Dictator's downfall

When US Marines entered the center of Baghdad, signaling Iraqi defeat, Saddam Hussein's statue was pulled down outside the Palestine Hotel by crowds of people celebrating the ousting from power of the brutal dictator.

Iran's nuclear program under president Mahmoud Ahmadinejad and Islamic extremist activity remain causes of concern in the Middle East.

IRANIAN NUCLEAR AMBITIONS

Iran's determination to develop its nuclear capacity have raised **international concern**. In 2007, the United Nations (UN) nuclear agency confirmed that Iran had enriched small amounts of uranium. Iran's president Mahmoud Ahmadinejad insisted that it was for peaceful purposes only. However, his hardline attitude toward attempts to regulate his nuclear program has led to speculation that Iran is seeking to develop atomic weapons and that military strikes may be organized against Iran to prevent this. The **UN Security Council** imposed sanctions on Iran for not halting the program.

ISLAMIC EXTREMISM

Recent years have seen a rise in Islamic extremist activity. Since the attacks on the US in 2001, terrorists have struck many times. In 2005 crowds at the Hindu festival of Diwali were bombed in Delhi, India. In Mumbai in 2008, a series of gun and bomb attacks by terrorists killed around 175 people. This extremist activity is often attributed to the **anti-Western feeling** generated by the Iraq War, although in India attacks are often linked to the activities of pro-Pakistani Kashmiri separatists.

